

WARCRAFT 3

When Blizzard, one of the most revered names in the RTS genre, debuted *Warcraft 3* in 2002, and followed up with the expansion pack *The Frozen Throne (TFT)* a year later, thousands of players were bitten by the *Warcraft* bug (they still are)! Unlike other RTSes, *WC3* is all about attacking and attacking soon, while building up. Micro-management is the key here, and most battles don't last more than 15 minutes, and are finished with Tier 1 units—with a few Tier 2s thrown in, and a level 2 (or 3) hero.

Micro and speed being tantamount, let's look at some of the most important strategies in the game. Bundled in these tips are some common-to-all-races shortcut keys as well.

 Use the [Shift] key while assigning workers (peons too) to build up. You can queue up multiple buildings this way to be built by a single worker. Never keep builder units idle!

 Don't hoard gold! If, in the first five minutes of the game, you have more than 350 gold, you are not rich—you are *slow*! Tech up the research tree, build more buildings and units. You aren't earning any interest on all that yellow!

 Attack and attack early! We can't stress on this enough. Don't let your opponent build up, research up, and for God's sake, don't let him expand! Keep harassing his base, all the while bolstering your forces, and teching up!

 Once you have your first hero, rally your troops to him by setting his portrait as a rally point (by right-clicking on it), for all troop production buildings. This way any newly created units will automatically take off after your hero, irrespective of where he is



Plan your attack, summon all you can!

on the map. This really saves a lot of time. Even your second (and third) hero should be rallied in this way.

 As Human you can use peasants to creep close to your base. Just convert some of them to militia (keep some at resources too), and use the rest. Your hero will level up faster, simply because he can attack earlier. Use on green-coloured creep camps only!

 Build orders are very important, but can change from opponent to opponent. Here's a sample—as soon as the game starts, put four workers on gold, queue a sixth worker, and put the fifth on your altar (hero production building). As soon as the second worker appears, put him on your primary troop production.

At the same time, remove one of the guys tasked on gold, and use him to build a farm (or your race equivalent structure), the seventh worker should be put on wood, while the fifth worker who should have finished the altar—task him back to the gold mine. You now have five gold miners, and the rest of your workforce should either build or focus on wood.

 When you attack, make sure to pull back units that are wounded, employ hit and run tactics, and you can keep a couple of powerful summoned units (if your hero is a summoner) just outside the enemy base. This way, while retreating, you get some free hits in case any enemies follow you.

 Even when you must pull back, only do so for a short distance, regroup, and focus again. Never pull back entirely from an enemy base.

 Focus-fire works wonders with ranged damage units, like riflemen, archers etc.—but *do not* use focus-fire when attacking with melee. Simply attack ground: focus firing will waste precious time, as your melee units will



Build clusters of buildings for your main base don't fan out



Use hero powers well! Flame Strike being judiciously used



Use powers on buildings with clusters of enemies close by for greater effect



Kill off weak enemies first, focus fire at work here

take damage, just getting into position to attack the unit you focused on.

 Don't lose units, and certainly don't lose heroes! Each hero lost is like minus 1000 gold, not to mention you stand a good chance of losing the game!

 If a unit—or even a hero—is perilously close to death, and you're still being attacked (or cannot heal the unit), use your own units to finish the job. Deny enemy heroes valuable experience points this way.

There you have it! All the basics you need to successfully see you through *Warcraft 3* multiplayer. It's highly addictive though, so do take a look at the time (your real-world clock) every once in awhile! ■